

A Practical Toolkit for a Documented Protection Gap

Many U.S. nonprofits operate in a complex safeguarding environment, with legal obligations spread across funding streams, licensed subsectors, employment rules, and state-specific requirements. The Crosswalk Project's research maps those rules against the Six Core Principles of the Inter-Agency Standing Committee (IASC), the top United Nations forum for coordinating humanitarian aid, and documents a specific gap: of the thirteen obligations in that standard, none is anchored by a U.S. requirement that both applies to nonprofits as a class and protects the people they serve. The toolkit is intended to make that landscape easier to navigate by translating the crosswalk findings into practical, usable references for nonprofit boards and leadership teams.

For small and mid-sized nonprofits, especially those serving children, youth, people with disabilities, survivors, and other high-trust communities, this can make it difficult to know what a complete safeguarding system should include. This toolkit turns the research into tools that organizations can review, tailor, and use.

Read the research: <https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.22022939>

Download the tools: <https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.22023886>

Open-Access Policy Instruments (CC BY 4.0)

- **Safeguarding Policy Template** — a policy template your organization can review, tailor, and adopt through its normal governance process.
- **30-Indicator Self-Assessment** — an internal readiness check your team can use to assess current safeguards, identify gaps, and prioritize next steps.
- **Adopter Feedback Form** — an optional 15–20 minute form for organizations that have used the tools; responses help refine the tools to fit organizations' needs and everyday use, and anonymity is the default.
- **Safeguarding Training Outlines** — fully scripted outlines for a staff orientation, an annual refresher, and a session on receiving and responding to reports.

The Policy Template and Self-Assessment are keyed to both the international standard and its closest U.S. legal anchors, allowing boards, funders, and leadership teams to verify coverage line by line.

***Note:** every tool is designed for self-directed adoption — nothing to register. Feedback is optional and helps refine the tools to fit organizations' needs and practicability.*

Using and Sharing the Tools

The Project's purpose is twofold: to test how well the international safeguarding standard translates into the operating realities of U.S. community organizations, and to give those organizations the systems they need to protect the people they serve. The toolkit is published open-access to serve both ends. I invite your organization to use it on a self-directed basis and to report back on what worked as written and what needed adaptation for your programs; that feedback helps refine the tools to fit organizations' needs and how they work in practice.

- **Use the tools on a self-directed basis:** run the Self-Assessment, use the Policy Template as a starting point, and apply the training outlines (Tool 4), which are included in the published toolkit.
- **Tell me what you find:** the Adopter Feedback Form (Tool 3) takes 15–20 minutes and is returned by email; anonymity is the default, and organizations that wish to be named as adopters can say so on the form.
- **Share the toolkit with your network:** a newsletter mention, resources-page listing, board packet, or funder referral can help it reach community-based organizations operating with limited staff capacity.

About the Principal Researcher

Saba Gul, Founder & Principal Researcher — a legal and policy professional (LL.B., LL.M.) with safeguarding and protection experience across UNHCR-funded, IOM, GIZ, and ICMC programs, including service as a designated PSEA Focal Point under the UN framework, case management within the U.S. Refugee Admissions Program, and current civic leadership as Amnesty International USA's Area Coordinator for Washington State. The Project is an independent, open-access research initiative.

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